

Limitations of Analyzing Self-Reported Grad Café Data

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The first limitation is that nobody is sampled onto Grad Café; people select themselves in. The 50,002 entries in my database are not a sample of graduate applicants, they are a sample of applicants who know the site exists, who care enough about the outcome to announce it, and who applied to the kinds of programs where posting is a norm. That shows up immediately in the analysis: 66.3% of entries are PhD applications, and my second original question found that the ten most-mentioned universities for Fall 2026 are all highly selective research universities such as Stanford, Berkeley, Yale, Princeton and MIT. Applicants to regional master's programs, professional degrees, or schools outside the United States and Canada are largely absent, so a figure like "47.89% international" describes who posts, not who applies. Outcome also drives posting behaviour. An acceptance from a famous program is something people want to share, a rejection is something people post to commiserate, and a middling or undecided result is often never posted at all, while a single applicant with ten results may post all ten and count ten times. My Fall 2025 acceptance percentage of 40.74% is therefore a statement about submitted entries, and it cannot be read as an admission rate for any program or for applicants in general, because both the numerator and the denominator depend on who felt like typing their result into a website.

The second limitation is that every field is self-reported, anonymous, and optional, so the data are both incomplete and unverifiable. Only 58.5% of entries report a GPA and only 2.9% (1,453 entries) report a usable GRE Quantitative score, and the people who fill in those boxes are plausibly the ones with numbers worth showing. That is the most likely explanation for the average GRE Quantitative score of 165.74 in my database, when the ETS reference population averages roughly 157: it does not mean applicants score 166 on average, it means applicants who volunteer a score on Grad Café do, and with many programs now GRE-optional the few who still report are a particularly strong group. The values that are reported are also inconsistent. While loading the data I found 2,316 "GRE Quantitative" values outside the 130–170 range (mostly combined totals in the 300s or old 200–800 scores) and 231 GPAs above 4.0, which I converted to missing; GPAs on 4.3, 5.0 or 10-point scales that happen to fall at or below 4.0 are indistinguishable from US GPAs and silently distort the averages. Universities and programs are free text ("MIT", "Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)", "Johns Hopkins University (Hot Piss Law)" all appear), which is why Questions 8 and 9 had to be matched with patterns and LLM-standardized names, and nothing stops a user from entering a fake or duplicate result. The right way to read this database is descriptive rather than inferential: it mathematically contains an average GPA of 3.75 among entries that report one, but it does not support the claim that graduate applicants, or even admitted students, have an average GPA of 3.75. Each number is accurate about the posts and only suggestive about the world.